with an ad hoc staff. This had also been the arrangement earlier, under 5 Mountain Division. This arrangement always surprised me as to why we still had to resort to an ad hoc sector even after the raising of a full-fledged Division. Equally surprising was the fact that there were three HQs along one ridge line, which was a bit of an overkill. Our Battalions being in the second and third tier of defences meant we also had reinforcement and counter-attack tasks, within the Divisional AOR as well as the AOR of 5 Mountain Division.

This was a lot to digest in one go, so we concentrated on our primary tasks first. Being in an HAA, even the reconnaissance had to be planned keeping acclimatization in mind, falling back to rest for the night at lower altitudes. During the first few weeks, especially before I had a chance to visit the forward areas, I had to rely almost solely on my memory of the field trip undertaken as a student in the HC course. Each field trip is followed by a war game specific to that command. For the Eastern Command war game, I had been made one of the enemy commanders, i.e. the PLA commander, so I had to think and plan like them. As a result, I was quite familiar with the names of various places on the Chinese as well as on our own side. I think that was the best part of the HC course, as it gave exposure to all the nooks and corners of the country. These field trips served me well in future tenures too.

Since we were a new raising, we had to make our own, new plans, right from mobilization onwards. Some of these plans were available to the older Divisions and Brigades, but they were hesitant to part with them, especially 5 Mountain Division, who felt that we had encroached on their turf. For 21 Mountain Division, CI/CT operations were the higher priority and conventional operations, which should actually have been the main priority, were relegated to a secondary role.

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